SELLING INTO JAPAN

The Silent Quarter

How a Japanese buying decision actually moves — and why you are present for only **two** of its five stages.

1	Quiet collection	you are visible
2	Internal translation	you are absent
3	Pre-consensus	you are absent
4	Formal approval	you are absent
5	The order	suddenly urgent

A FIELD GUIDE · 12 PAGES

SAVE THIS

The decision is manufactured before it is announced.

Western selling is built around a moment of persuasion. A meeting, a demo, a room, a decision-maker who can say yes.

In many Japanese organisations that moment does not exist. Agreement is assembled quietly, in advance, by people you will never meet — and the meeting you were preparing for is where the finished agreement gets confirmed, not formed.

> **WHAT THIS CHANGES**
>
> Your job is not to convince someone in a room. It is to make sure that what you handed over survives a journey through a building you cannot see. Everything else follows from that one shift.

1

STAGE ONE · YOU ARE VISIBLE

Quiet collection

Someone has been told to look into it. They are not a buyer, and they will not tell you that.

They download the deck. They read the pricing page four times. They open your email and don't reply. If they do write, the questions are narrow and factual, and they arrive without context.

THE MOST COMMON EARLY KILL

Your first Japanese contact is usually a **researcher**, not a decision-maker. Western qualification frameworks are built to filter exactly this person out — no budget, no authority, no timeline. Disqualify them and you have disqualified the only person inside the company who was willing to carry you.

INSTEAD

Treat the researcher as the client. Their real need is not your product — it is to not look foolish for having raised it.

2

STAGE TWO · YOU ARE ABSENT

Internal translation

Your offer has to become an internal problem statement that stands up without you attached to it.

Not a translation into Japanese. A translation into *their* terms: which existing problem this solves, what it costs, what happens if they do nothing, and who inside the company will be affected.

> **THE REFRAME THAT CHANGES YOUR MATERIAL**
>
> You are not selling a product. You are supplying **raw material for a document you will never see**, written by someone with less authority than you assumed, for readers whose objections you were never told about.

Most foreign vendors do not lose here. They become **untranslatable** — impressive in a live demo, impossible to summarise in one internal page.

3

STAGE THREE · YOU ARE ABSENT

Pre-consensus

Objections are collected privately, one desk at a time, before any formal meeting happens.

Everyone who will be affected is approached individually. Concerns are raised and resolved out of sight. The purpose is explicit: by the time a meeting occurs, it must contain no conflict.

WHY YOUR BIG MEETING FELT STRANGE

A Japanese meeting is usually not where a decision is made. It is where a decision is **confirmed**. Sellers who prepare for a persuasion event find twenty polite minutes and unanimous agreement — or they never get the meeting at all, because consensus failed silently and no one is going to tell them.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

Ask your contact who else is affected — then give them a separate answer for each of those people. That is the actual work of this stage.

4

STAGE FOUR · YOU ARE ABSENT

Formal approval

A written proposal circulates for approval, desk by desk. Any one of them can hold it.

This is the stage that produces the long silence. It is procedural, it is slow, and it generates no outward signal at all — because nobody rejects loudly and nobody announces progress.

> THE HARDEST THING TO ACCEPT
>
> At this stage, approval and rejection look **identical** from outside. Silence carries no information. Any conclusion you draw from it is invented, and the conclusion overseas teams invent is almost always "we lost."

Note what this rules out: reading engagement signals, testing interest with a deadline, or interpreting a slow reply. None of those instruments work here.

5

STAGE FIVE · SUDDENLY URGENT

The order

Once approved, it moves fast — and expects you to already be ready.

Procurement appears. Documents are requested with short deadlines. Start dates are assumed. After a quarter of nothing, the pace inverts completely, and hesitation now reads as unreliability.

THE CRUEL PART

A large share of overseas teams have already disengaged by the time this arrives. The contact goes back to the vendor who is still standing there — and it is often not the better product. It is the one that was still present.

PRACTICAL

Have the paperwork ready before you need it. Company documents, security answers, invoicing format, and a named person who can sign. Assembling these under a two-day deadline is how good deals become bad first impressions.

Where you actually are, and aren't

1 **Quiet collection** PRESENT
You can still supply, answer, and shape

2 **Internal translation** ABSENT
Only what you already handed over is in the room

3 **Pre-consensus** ABSENT
Objections raised and settled without you

4 **Formal approval** ABSENT
No signal is emitted in either direction

5 **The order** PRESENT
You are needed immediately, or replaced

What to send, and when

STAGE	WHAT THEY ACTUALLY NEED	WHAT TO SEND
1 · Collection	Facts they can quote without checking with you	Plain specifications, real pricing, a one-page summary in Japanese
2 · Translation	A problem statement in their words, not yours	The before/after in one page. What breaks if nothing changes
3 · Pre-consensus	A separate answer for each affected department	Security, support, exit, cost of switching — each self-contained
4 · Approval	Nothing. Do not push.	One useful, non-demanding update. Then wait.
5 · Order	Speed and completeness	Documents already prepared, and a named signer

FAILURE PATTERNS

Three moves that kill your advocate

Each of these is standard practice somewhere else, and each one removes the person carrying you.

- **Applying a deadline.**
  Artificial urgency does not accelerate a process your contact does not control. It transfers your pressure onto them, in front of their colleagues.
- **Discounting to force movement.**
  A price that drops without a reason invalidates the numbers already circulating internally — and makes your advocate look like they were wrong the first time.
- **Escalating over their head.**
  Going to the executive is the single fastest way to end the relationship. You have just told the organisation your contact could not handle it.

> THE UNDERLYING RULE
>
> Every action should make your contact **safer** internally. If it makes them look rushed, wrong, or bypassed, it costs you the deal even when it works on the timeline.

When silence really is a no

Patience is the right default, but it is not free. Three signals that the process has actually ended:

- **Your contact stops answering factual questions.**
  Not slow — different. An advocate still under way will answer a narrow, easy question, because it costs them nothing.
- **The affected departments were never named.**
  If nobody could tell you who else is involved, the internal proposal probably never reached them.
- **A reorganisation or a personnel change landed on your contact.**
  Proposals in circulation rarely survive their sponsor moving desks. This is not a rejection of you, and it is still an ending.

> **HOW TO CLOSE IT**
>
> End warmly and leave the door open with a specific, dated reason to return. Japanese markets are small, careers are long, and the same person appears again at a different company.

THE TAKEAWAY

You cannot shorten the silent quarter. You can decide what is inside it.

What travels through that building is whatever you handed over before it went quiet. Almost every overseas team I work with has lost a Japanese deal they had already won — not to a competitor, but to the assumption that nothing was happening.

Have you had a Japanese deal go quiet?
How long did you wait before you wrote it off?

Japan Market Setup · fixed scope · 14 business days

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